
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's football

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Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's football

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McFarlane holds own against Guardiola

Calum McFarlane's [unexpected battle with Pep Guardiola](#) brought back memories of the 2021 League Cup final, when Ryan Mason, Tottenham's 29-year-old interim coach, faced the significant task of trying to outsmart one of the greatest managers in the game's history. For Mason there was the added baggage of Spurs' 13-year trophy drought; for McFarlane, making his senior management debut, it was Chelsea's astonishingly bad recent record against Manchester City. Four and a half years have passed since Chelsea last beat Guardiola's side, when Thomas Tuchel's team triumphed in the Champions League final, and a draw on Sunday took that winless run to 12 matches. But Enzo Fernández's injury-time equaliser, combining with [the midweek upheaval at Stamford Bridge](#), made it a triumphant point, something Enzo Maresca didn't achieve against City during his tenure. **Taha Hashim**

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Match report: [Manchester City 1-1 Chelsea](#)

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Liverpool fail to shut up shop

Florian Wirtz was one of the positives for [Liverpool](#) in their 2-2 draw with Fulham but the £116m summer signing was not happy despite scoring for the second time in three games. "I was happy that I scored but I'd rather take the three points," Wirtz said. "It's not what we want, we want more. We have to get better but it's still a process." To get more, though, Liverpool have to be more commanding. They keep letting games run out of control and Arne Slot seems short of solutions. Liverpool's manager was not impressed with the defending that led to Harrison Reed's equaliser. It was a stunning and unlikely strike from the Fulham substitute but Liverpool should not make the mistake of thinking they were the victims of misfortune. They almost let 2-0 leads slip against Wolves and Tottenham last month. The season will remain a struggle until they tighten up when ahead. **Jacob Steinberg**

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Match report: [Fulham 2-2 Liverpool](#)

Rice backs Gyökeres to fire for Gunners

Viktor Gyökeres hasn't found his goalscoring touch for Arsenal yet, but Declan Rice insists the Sweden striker is still having a huge influence for the league leaders. Rice scored twice against [Bournemouth](#) as Mikel Arteta's side completed a stirring comeback on the south coast, but Gyökeres has now gone 10 matches without finding the net from open play. His all-round performance was slightly improved against Andoni Iraola's side and Gyökeres played an important role in Arsenal's crucial second, even if he rarely looked like adding to his seven goals in 23 appearances so far. "It's tough for him because defenders are so tight on him, and there's no space for him at all," said Rice. "All the boys are with him because of what he is doing for us, even though he hasn't scored, how he is helping us as a team to press, hold the ball up. I think good things are going to come." **Ed Aarons**

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Match report: [Bournemouth 2-3 Arsenal](#)

Amorim needs Sesko to sharpen up

With Ruben Amorim starting nine defensive-minded players at Elland Road on Sunday afternoon, the onus naturally fell on the remaining two to lead Manchester United's attack. Matheus Cunha's fine form continued with the goal that earned the visitors a point, but Sesko's travails continued. The Slovenian has scored just two goals since his big-money move to Old Trafford, and none since October. Granted, his service was limited on occasions and United's attacking play was stunted by so many defensive players on the pitch, but Sesko struggled to make an impact once again, spurning a glorious chance to potentially claim all three points late on. As we enter the new year, there is justification for Amorim to ask for more from a player who is yet to fully find his feet in the Premier League. **Aaron Bower**

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Match report: [Leeds 1-1 Manchester United](#)

Le Fée leaves Spurs in a muddle

Régis Le Bris made the brave decision to partner Granit Xhaka with Enzo Le Fée in midfield at Tottenham. The Frenchman was asked to play a deeper role than he is used to and acquitted himself well. With Spurs in the lead, though, Le Bris pushed Le Fée further forward in the second half and his performance was a delight. Picking up little pockets of space, the former Roma forward became a major factor in Sunderland's push for an equaliser. After directing a header on to a post from Nordi Mukiele's pass, Le Fée then created Brian Brobbey's goal before Spurs knew how to stop it. A sharp first-time pass back into the striker's path gave him a chance he could not miss. Sunderland have had plenty of success stories this season but, now he has adapted to the pace of the [Premier League](#), Le Fée's campaign keeps getting better. **Billy Munday**

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Match report: [Tottenham 1-1 Sunderland](#)

Nuno wastes chance to bed in Pablo

Everything about West Ham's defeat at Wolves was embarrassing, from start to finish. Nuno Espírito Santo left three available substitutions unmade, an indication of the confidence he has in his bench. The manager named his new signing, Pablo Felipe, among the substitutes but despite the chronic failings of his team, who failed to have a single shot on target, Nuno decided it would be unfair to send the new recruit on for his debut, having only arrived from Gil Vicente on Friday. Before this season the 22-year-old's career was relatively nondescript but, after 10 goals in 13 league games in Portugal, the Hammers must harness his newfound confidence and hope he is not a Brazilian Michael Ricketts. West Ham are desperate for goals and Pablo needs to adapt quickly to the Premier League. It would have been a free hit for him at Molineux, especially with a crucial game at home to Forest on Tuesday. Joining in January is difficult but, if Nuno wants him to adapt, he will need to get the striker on the pitch as much as possible. **Will Unwin**

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Match report: [Wolves 3-0 West Ham](#)

Miley makes another big statement

Lewis Miley dared Eddie Howe to drop him thanks to another outstanding performance out of position at right-back. Quite apart from excelling defensively, never misplacing a pass and creating Newcastle's opening goal for Bruno Guimarães in Sunday's 2-0 win against [Crystal Palace](#), the astonishingly mature 19-year-old midfielder raised the tone in an untidy game. With Tino Livramento and Kieran Trippier both fit again and ready to resume at right-back, the question will be whether Howe can find a place for Miley in central midfield against Leeds at St James' Park on Wednesday night. "Lewis has been incredible," said Newcastle's manager, who may be tempted to rest Sandro Tonali against Daniel Farke's team after the Italy midfielder was left bruised by some tough Palace challenges. "You wouldn't know right-back isn't Lewis's natural position. He's excelled in it. He's doing a great job for the team." Future Newcastle sides will surely be built around Miley. **Louise Taylor**

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Match report: [Newcastle 2-0 Crystal Palace](#)

Is Dyche effect wearing thin at Forest?

Sean Dyche's initial impact at [Nottingham Forest](#) has been admirable, but do they have a Plan B? Forest are averaging a point a game since Dyche's arrival in October (1.4 if Europa League games are included), but they have lost four in a row. Only once this season have they come from behind to win – against Leeds in November. Their counterattacking abilities remain, though are less effective than when Chris Wood (now injured) and Anthony Elanga (sold to Newcastle) were regulars last season. But they do still look well-organised when defending deep. Forest are generally compact, alert, combative and aligned when the scores are level, or they lead. But when the other team scores first, and they have to commit more players ahead of the ball, the game becomes more stretched. In Saturday's 3-1 defeat at Villa Park, Forest were easily taken apart after giving the ball away; they cannot afford a repeat in Tuesday's crucial trip to West Ham. **Peter Lansley**

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Match report: [Aston Villa 3-1 Nottingham Forest](#)

Thiago's hot streak ends away-day blues

It was hard to reconcile Brentford's performance at Everton with a team in possession of one of the worst away records in the league, so controlled and dominant were Keith Andrews's visitors, but despite seven losses on the road this season their ambitions might have to be revised. Asked what Brentford's target for the second half of the campaign should be, Kevin Schade said: "The main goal is not to go down, obviously. Then I would say it's not a goal but a dream we can achieve, if everything goes right, to qualify for Europe. For me, personally, to go to the World Cup, and I need good games for that and the team as well." With Igor Thiago in such prolific form, Schade and [Brentford](#) have that platform. Schade said of his teammate: "He's very important because we always had players like this, for example Ivan Toney, Bryan [Mbuemo] and Yoane Wissa before, and now him. The link-up play for the team gets better from game-to-game and this is what we need, not only him scoring." **Andy Hunter**

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Match report: [Everton 2-4 Brentford](#)

Burnley lag behind promoted rivals

There's been a twisted sense of solidarity among the relegated clubs in the last couple of seasons. They've come up together from the Championship – and instantly gone down together, too. But Burnley's journey this season has become increasingly lonely, with the other new boys, [Sunderland](#) and Leeds, appearing safer and safer. As Daniel Farke's side extended their unbeaten run to seven games and Sunderland made it five without defeat, Scott Parker was forced to confront a new low in Burnley's loss to Brighton with just two points collected from their last 11 matches. Having praised his side's application in defeat previously this season, this time there was just a series of glum admissions from the head coach, who pointed to an absence of belief among his players and said they didn't deserve anything from the match. Six points from safety doesn't sound too bad, but Parker's analysis makes it feel pretty dismal. **TH**

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Match report: [Brighton 2-0 Burnley](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	20	26	48
2	Man City	20	26	42
3	Aston Villa	20	9	42
4	Liverpool	20	4	34
5	Chelsea	20	11	31
6	Man Utd	20	4	31
7	Brentford	20	4	30
8	Sunderland	20	2	30
9	Newcastle	20	4	29
10	Brighton	20	3	28
11	Fulham	20	-1	28
12	Everton	20	-2	28
13	Tottenham Hotspur	20	4	27
14	Crystal Palace	20	-1	27
15	AFC Bournemouth	20	-7	23
16	Leeds	20	-7	22
17	Nottm Forest	20	-14	18
18	West Ham	20	-20	14
19	Burnley	20	-19	12
20	Wolverhampton	20	-26	6

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